

larly. For example a tiny keypad may be a hindrance for those with large hands, or maybe the keypad feedback may not be to your liking. The layout of the keys themselves is also important.

Intel's *Core 2 Duo* processor is the most widespread and 80 per cent of all the notebooks I saw had this family of processor. With falling CPU prices even entry level notebooks have given up the cheaper Celeron and Pentium Dual Core processors for the faster Core 2 Duo. A few of the smaller notebook have also started featuring Intel's Atom processor which is a highly power efficient solution, and powers most tiny notebooks. AMDs Turion X2 (dual core) processors are also available, but in a very limited notebook models. The Core 2 Duo family is very large—the T5xxx series are suitable for regular office and Internet use PCs. The faster T7xxx series are suitable for multimedia PCs, although the newer T8xxx and T9xxx processors are faster and run cooler owing to the smaller 45nm fabrication process opposed to the 65nm fabrication for the 7xxx series. Unless you want to game or do audio/video encoding the T8xxx and T9xxx processors are overkill. The L7xxx are low power consumption processors at par with the T5xxx series for performance, and the U7xxx (ultra low power consumption) are for those who want less processing power but more battery life. For memory, I recommend at least 2 GB for all users—notebook memory is dirt cheap. Gamers should look for around 3 GB. Keep in mind that Windows Vista is memory hog. Also upgrading a notebooks memory isn't as simple as upgrading a PC, so beware. Upgrading a CPU is even more tedious.

In terms of usability, some notebooks offer tablet PC features. This basically means a touchscreen that can pivot and swivel.

Most of the tablet notebooks are really compact i.e. 12.1 inch screen size—a plus, if size is a factor for you. If you're looking for something really compact, there are a whole new bunch of notebooks from ASUS, MSI, HP and Acer which offer Intel Atom processors, one or two gigabytes of RAM, 80 to 160 GB hard drives with exceptionally small screens—eight to ten inches. These are very compact and lightweight as a result. However, if you type a lot, the keyboards on such compact notebooks may be somewhat cramped. For those looking for compact powerhouses with spacious keypads the 12.1 and 13.3 inch categories are worth looking at, although Sony does have an 11.1 inch model which is also very compact.

A 15.4 inch notebook is usually considered de facto for anyone looking at a notebook, although for me these notebooks seem bulky. I'd prefer a 14.1 inch screen, which offers the same components at no added cost, but is lighter and smaller. For those looking at a large screen notebook (desktop replacement) and they don't intend to cart it around, 17-inch laptops are also available, although most of these are quite pricey, simply because they have high-end configurations. Acer does have some non-standard screen sizes—their Aspire 6920 and 8920G (16 inches and 18.4 inches respectively).

You must remember that a notebook is a consumer product, much like a plasma TV, or a home theatre system, and warranties play an important role. All brands offer warranties but you have to consider things like availability of service centres, time taken to respond, the nature of the warranty and its duration, and even the quality of service. The latter point is something that existing consumers of that brand can share with you. All information is helpful in some way or another.

Among the brands available I came across Sony, HP/Compaq, Lenovo, Acer, LG, Toshiba, Fujitsu and Dell. Dell is unique in certain aspects as they allow you to configure the laptop with your choice of components as well as buy preconfigured notebooks. If you know what you're doing, configuring your own notebook is very beneficial, as you can opt for the correct combination of components.

HPs DV series and Sony's Vaio are some of the most attractive looking notebooks around, although I felt HPs DV2000 and DV6000 series, (their multimedia notebook series), are the most attractive with their satin smooth finishes and the great-looking artwork on the lids. The Compaq notebooks are priced lower than the HPs (in general) and the higher models sport the same slick finishes. These make good buys for someone on a budget.

Some Sony Vaio's are really beautiful, some are mediocre looking. Dell's Inspiron series are available on display, but their XPS series, which offer high-end performance parts, aren't. You'll have to contact Dell India if you want an XPS notebook, and you can configure these on Dell's Web site for their pricing. Lenovo's ThinkPad series are very light, very well built, and targeted at businessmen, while their Y series are for home users. Fujitsu offers mostly business notebooks with charcoal grey finishes that may not attract—however, for the corporate fraternity, these are light and rugged. LG has some nice looking notebooks, mostly finished in variations of white. ASUS is a surprise entrant for me, because they're mostly renowned for their motherboards and graphics cards. Nonetheless they have some really attractive, albeit highly-priced models. The table below lists the models I came across with their prices and basic specifications: ☐

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Notebooks At Malls							
Brand	Model No	Screen Size	Geared Towards	CPU	RAM	HDD	Price
Acer	Aspire 1	8.9 inches	Ultra Portability	N270 (Atom)	1 GB	80 GB	22999
Acer	Aspire 6920	16 inches	Entertainment / Home	T7300	3 GB	320 GB	49,999
Acer	Aspire 8920G	18.4 inches	Entertainment	T7500	3 GB	320 GB	79999
ASUS	U65G	12.1 inches	Portable	T8300	2 GB	250 GB	92999
Dell	Inspiron 1525	15.4 inches	Workhorse / Home	T7250	2 GB	160 GB	40900
Fujitsu	S6510	14.1 inches	Corporate	T7500	2 GB	160 GB	80000
HP	DV 6704 TU	15.4 inches	Entertainment / Home	T5450	2 GB	160 GB	39990
HP	DV 2701TX	14.1 inches	Business	T5450	2 GB	160 GB	45999
Lenovo	X300	15.4 inches	Corporate	U7100	2 GB	60 GB (solid state)	135000
Lenovo	Y510 7758 52Q	15.4 inches	Entertainment	T2330	1 GB	120 GB	37999
Lenovo	Y510 7758 53Q	15.4 inches	Entertainment	T5450	2 GB	160 GB	44999
Sony	Vaio VGN-TZ37GN/R	11.1 inches	Ultra Compact	U7700	2 GB	120 GB	114900
Sony	Vaio VGN-FZ35GN	15.4 inches	Entertainment / Home	T8100	2 GB	200 GB	59990

☐ My budget is under Rs 60,000, and I need a PC primarily for gaming and also 3D rendering, and multimedia usage. I already have a good UPS, LCD monitor and speakers. Please suggest a good PC. I also want a good DVD writer, power supply and cabinet. A CPU cooler is a must for me as I will overclock my CPU. I need at least 500 GB of HDD space.

Yantesh Dhir

Dear Yantesh, a fast dual-core benefits gaming more, and a slower quad core will yield faster results in 3D rendering. I'm giving you two suggestions—one based on a Core 2 Duo, and the other on a Core 2 Quad. Here you go:

PC Config		
Component	My Suggestion(s)	Price (Rs)
Processor	Core 2 Duo E8500 / Core 2 Quad Q6600	9,000 / 9,600
Motherboard	ASUS P5Q Pro (Intel P45 based)	9,000
RAM	Kingston 4 GB (2 x 2 GB DDR2 800 MHz)	4,000
Graphics Card	EVGA / ZOTAC 9800GTX	12,500
HDD	Seagate 7200.11 500 GB SATA	3,900
PSU	Corsair HX620W	6,300
Cabinet	CoolerMaster CM690	3,900
CPU cooler	Thermalright Ultima 90i	2,500
DVD Writer	LG H55n	1,100
Total		Rs 52,200 / 52,800

You'll also need a good 90-mm fan for your CPU cooler. I suggest an NMB or a Panaflo medium-speed fan, which will cost another Rs 600. Buy Artic Silver MX2. It's a superior thermal paste to use when adding the heatsink to your CPU. Just clean both the CPU heat spreader and the contact area of the heatsink and put some of this thermal paste on both surfaces—ensure a thin layer.

☐ I want to buy a DSLR, as photography is my hobby. I would like your advice on a suitable DSLR with a 10-12 MP sensor, 1/4000 shutter speed and lithium battery. My budget is about Rs 15,000 to 20,000.

Pariza

Street prices of DSLR cameras are much lower than what prices are advertised by online stores. A Nikon D40x could well be available for under the Rs 20,000 mark in your locality, since I've seen the street price of this camera as low as Rs 17,000 (without a bill). The D40 would be lower in price, but availability might be an issue. These are the only two DSLRs within that price range. The Canon EOS 400D is priced at around Rs 26,000, and therefore out of your budget.

☐ I want to buy a cellphone. My basic need is music with a good camera. It should also have proper functionality. My budget is Rs 10,000. Could you also suggest a suitable set of earplugs within my budget?

Shubham Mitra

I'd point you towards a Sony Ericsson K810i. It's got a 3.2-megapixel camera, crisp screen, and great music quality. This phone is an older model now, but should be available for as low as Rs 8,000 (street price). For its price, it's a

beauty and excellent value for money. For earplugs, look at the Creative EP630 for Rs 800 or so.

☐ I have purchased an Intel E8400 processor, Cooler Master CM690 case and 500 W PSU, Corsair XMS 2 PC6400 RAM, WD 5000AAKS HDD, ViewSonic G90fB CRT monitor. However, I am unable to decide on the motherboard. I need the PC for basic tasking and such. However, at a later stage, I want to buy an 8800GT graphics card. Should I buy an onboard-solution based motherboard or a non-integrated chipset with an add-on graphics card?

Ram Mohan

Firstly, why do you want to wait for the GeForce 8800GT? It's already within reach at around Rs 10,000. The 9800GTX is available for Rs 12,000. Regarding your query, I recommend you invest in an Intel G33-based chipset solution, which will allow you to use integrated graphics till you get a discrete video solution. Look at Gigabyte, MSI or ASUS for brands. I don't recommend buying a cheap graphics card for now and then ditching it in favour of a faster card a few months later on. It's a waste of money.

☐ I'm going to buy a graphics card on a budget of up to Rs 13,000. Is ATI Radeon 4850 a good choice? It's priced almost the same as the GeForce 8800GT. Which one is better, and which company should I look at? Is there a cooling solution for this card? Should I wait till such a cooling solution arrives?

Vishal Deepak

I recommend neither the GeForce 8800GT nor the Radeon HD4850. The former is a slower card, and the latter, though faster, is a hot solution that can run up to 85 degrees on load, and even more, if it's not ventilated properly, which makes me fear for the life of the card. NVIDIA's GeForce 9800GTX is a solution that is more powerful than the 8800GT and cooler than the HD4850 by around 10-15 degrees. Look for brands like Gigabyte, ZOTAC, EVGA, ASUS and XFX. Expect prices to be around Rs 12,000.

☐ I plan to buy a desktop PC. My choices are either Compaq 3470 1L or Lenovo 5313 1BQ. Are either of these is a good buy?

Jaswinder Kaur

Why not look at an assembled PC? You'll get a better configuration for the same price. Among the options you mentioned, I suggest the Lenovo 5313 1BQ. The E7200 Core 2 Duo processor that this desktop has, is rather new and should get your job done, which by the way you've not mentioned (usage patterns). Please opt for 2 GB of system memory, and go with a single 250-GB HDD. I also recommend a 19-inch LCD. ☐

Ask Away!

Want a tech product, but don't know how to go about buying it? E-mail agent001@thinkdigit.com with your complete contact details, and he might answer them here! Please note that Agent001 only answers purchase-related questions in this space.